

ZapBox Compact – User Manual

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Overview

The **ZapBox Compact** is an electronic switch for Bitcoin Lightning payments. A payment via the Lightning Network triggers a switched output – ideal for vending machines, presentations, event control, and many other applications.

Basic Equipment

Component	Description
Microcontroller	T-Display-S3 with 1.9" LCD display
Front panel	Available with 35° or 90° display front (90° also available for panel mounting)
Input	USB-C (Power IN)
Output	USB-A socket
Controls	Two on-board micro buttons
Switch 1	3-position slide switch (AUTO / OFF / ON)
Switch 2	2-position slide switch (Invert Output)
Option BTC Ticker	Activatable via the Web Installer
Option NFC Module	For Bolt Cards (NTAG424 DNA) and standard NTAG213/215/216 (with LNURL-withdraw)

Views



Figure 1: Front view



Figure 2: Rear view

Connections

Input – USB-C socket for power supply (5V)

Power the device via the **Power IN** connector using a USB-C cable with **5 V DC (max. 5 A)**.

Note: The Power IN connector is not "intelligent". Some chargers or power modules with a USB-C output do not recognise the ZapBox and will not supply power. In this case, use a **USB-A output** from your power supply or a different power source.

Input – USB-C socket on the microcontroller (data access, behind right side panel)

To read data from or transfer data to the device, connect the ZapBox to a computer or laptop:

1. On the **right side of the front panel** there is a small, concealed flap.
2. Open the flap by sliding it to the right from below using a **narrow screwdriver**.
3. Connect a USB-C cable to the microcontroller port underneath.



Figure: Opening the panel and USB-C connection for data

Important Notice: The USB port directly connected to the microcontroller is intended exclusively for flashing firmware and transferring configuration parameters. During the flashing process, no load must be connected to or switched on at the output, as this may lead to **malfunctions or damage to the microcontroller**.

It is therefore recommended to:

- not connect any load to the output while the USB connection is active, **or**
- additionally connect the regular **Power-IN** input to the same power supply. This ensures that the current for the power relay does not flow through the microcontroller and overload it.

Output – USB-A socket (switched 5V)

The USB socket is switched via a relay contact. The **total load** across the sockets should **not exceed 3 A**.

Controls

The ZapBox has two small **on-board micro buttons** connected directly to the microcontroller. All functions are accessible via the micro buttons. In addition, the ZapBox has a reset button on the underside of the front panel and two slide switches on the side.

Function Overview – Micro Buttons

Function	Micro Button
Display help page	Press HELP 1×
Next page / product change	Press NEXT 1×
Display REPORT page	Press HELP 2×
Enter config mode	Hold NEXT for at least 5 seconds

Function Overview – Slide Switches

The ZapBox Compact has two slide switches.

Switch 1 – Three-position slide switch (AUTO / OFF / ON)

Position	Function
A (AUTO)	Automatic mode – normal operation
0 (OFF)	Power supply interrupted – output OFF
1 (ON)	Output permanently ON (with Switch 2 - Inverse = OFF)

Switch 2 – Two-position slide switch (standard / inverted)

Position	Function
Std. (Standard)	The output is de-energised at rest (0 V). After switching, 5 V is applied to the USB sockets.
Inv. (Inverse)	The output is at 5 V at rest. After switching, the output changes to 0 V (inverted switching).

Note: If Switch 2 is set to **Inv.** and Switch 1 is in **position 1**, the output is **OFF** – contrary to normal operation.

Setup and Commissioning

The ZapBox is tested after production and shipped with the current firmware – however, it is not yet configured. The software is actively being developed, so it is recommended to flash the ZapBox with the latest firmware right from the start and then perform the configuration. A convenient **Web Installer** is available for this.

Here is a step-by-step guide for setup:

1. Open the right side panel of the front panel as described above under "Input – USB-C socket on the microcontroller".
2. Connect the ZapBox via the USB-C port with a cable to a computer.
3. Open a Chromium-based browser, for example Google Chrome, Microsoft Edge, Brave, Vivaldi, Opera, or [Helium](#).

4. Navigate to the Web Installer page <https://installer.zapbox.space/>.
5. Flash the latest "Latest" version as described in step 1 of the Web Installer.
6. After flashing, close the small window and go to step 3 – Load config values. Select the  **Connect** button.
7. You should now see ☒ **Connected** and ☒ **Config mode** in the green field, provided the ZapBox is now in **SERIAL CONFIG MODE**. The display should show this. If not, check step 2 – Prepare connection.
8. The ZapBox requires three parameters: **WiFi SSID** / **WiFi password** / **Device settings string**. You receive the Device Settings String from your LNbits wallet. To do so, add the **Bitcoin Switch** or **ZapBox** extension. The ZapBox extension also supports the NFC module; otherwise they are identical.
9. Once all three parameters have been entered, save them using the  **Write Config** button and restart the ZapBox using the  **Restart** button.

That should be all. After initialisation, the ZapBox will display the QR code of the product and is ready for the first payment and subsequent action on the USB output.

In case of errors or faults, please refer to the "Error Detection & Report" and "Troubleshoot" sections further down on the Web Installer page.

Option: NFC Module

Depending on the configuration, an NFC module is built into the **top of the ZapBox**. Alternatively, the module is also available separately. The ZapBox currently supports the following card types:

- **Bolt Cards** (NTAG424)
- **LNURL-Withdraw** via NTAG21x (213 / 215 / 216)

The LNbits [ZapBox Extension](#) is required for this feature. It must be supported by the LNbits server.

Technical Specifications

Property	Value
Supply voltage	5 V DC via USB-C
Maximum input current	5.0 A
Output current	max. 3.0 A (recommended)
Display	1.9" LCD (T-Display-S3)
Communication	Wi-Fi (ESP32-S3)
Payment protocol	Bitcoin Lightning Network

Safety Instructions

- Operate the device only with the specified supply voltage.
- Do not exceed the maximum current ratings of the outputs.
- Do not perform any work on the relay contacts under load.

- The device is not suitable for use in humid or wet environments.
- Keep out of reach of children.

Further Links

Resource	Link
Overview of all ZapBox models	https://zapbox.space/
Web Installer, quick overview & troubleshooting	https://installer.zapbox.space/
Detailed documentation (parameters & functions)	https://ereignishorizont.xyz/zapbox/
GitHub repository (software, schematics, 3D print files, manuals)	https://github.com/AxelHamburch/ZapBox
ZapBox Extension	https://github.com/AxelHamburch/zapbox_extension
LNbits	https://lnbits.com/

Subject to changes and errors. As of: 2026